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Beginnings: Why the Doctrine of Creation Matters for the Integration of Psychology and Christianity

William B. Whitney
Azusa Pacific University, USA

Abstract
This article considers what integration efforts in psychology would look like if informed by a trinitarian account of creation. Further theological reflection about the doctrine of creation reveals four key conclusions that are valuable for conceiving the relationship between theology and psychology: (1) The goodness of the created realm establishes the investigation and exploration of human nature through science and psychology; (2) Human nature can be explored through psychology because God's providential care allows a certain "order" of creation to be preserved despite the reality of sin; (3) God endows humanity with creative abilities to discover and develop the created realm and culture through the science of psychology; (4) God's trinitarian relations with the world establishes the theological basis for the social, embodied, and relational aspects of human nature that are able to be discerned through the study of psychology. The implications that these four key conclusions have for psychological research and clinical psychology will also be discussed.

Keywords
Christian, theology, integration, faith, creation, science, religion

A simple way to conceptualize the integration between psychology and theology can be understood as occurring on two basic trajectories that are interrelated. One trajectory demonstrates how Christian theology might broaden, critique, and inform features within psychology, while a second trajectory expresses how psychology might inform and broaden certain aspects of Christian theological belief. While all integrationists working in psychology and Christianity will agree that Christian theology should inform and shape psychology, integrationists will differ as to how much (if any) the discipline of psychology can actually clarify, broaden, inform, and even critique Christian theology.

While both trajectories are necessary to attend to, for this article, focus will be placed on the first trajectory mentioned, that is, how Christian theology may broaden and inform one's thinking about psychology. As James Beck observes, one area that needs strengthening among evangelical integrative efforts is in "upgrading" the quality of biblical and theological material that is integrated with

Corresponding author:
William B. Whitney, Department of Psychology, Azusa Pacific University, 901 East Alosta Ave., Azusa, CA 91702, USA.
Email: wwhitney@apu.edu

psychology (Beck, 2003).[1] With this in mind, this article seeks to demonstrate the unique resources that the Christian tradition provides for integrative efforts in psychology. More specifically, this article will consider how the doctrine of creation and related doctrinal loci bear on the both the content and method of the integrative process with psychology, while also demonstrating how a trinitarian account of creation has implications for psychology research and clinical practice.

Opening sections of this article are entitled "Why Creation?" and "Beginnings." These sections will demonstrate why creation has been neglected within the integration literature, and how creation establishes certain norms that are essential for the practice of integration. These sections provide some more theological depth to the doctrine of creation than is commonly discussed within integrative circles, and offer some foundational theological resources that have potential to influence one's approach to many of the psychological subdisciplines. These beginning threads of the article's argument provide the theological resources that will be drawn upon in the middle and final sections of the article as the ramifications for psychological research and psychotherapy are discussed. Next, this article will examine four key conclusions that are valuable for conceiving the relationship between theology and psychology. These four conclusions form the backbone of the article and explicate which distinct features of the Christian doctrine of creation deepen and broaden some key aspects of psychological study. This portion of the work highlights how human activity in psychology can be rightly understood as creative abilities given to humanity by God in order to shape and develop the created order. The final section of the article will examine some of the major implications that a trinitarian understanding of creation has for psychological research and psychotherapy. This concluding section will highlight some of the ways that humans are enabled through the Spirit to join with the work of God to redeem patterns of human behavior through psychotherapy or psychological research.

Why Creation?

Within the current integration dialogue among evangelical Christians, the primary theological doctrine that receives much attention from psychologists is the conception of the *imago Dei* (Puffer, 2007), with the discussion leaning towards the negative aspects of humanity related to sin (Entwistle & Moroney, 2011). This focus is understandable considering that theological anthropology is an examination of human personhood from a Christian perspective. Moreover, the emphasis on the *imago Dei* and sin in the integrative literature makes sense considering that psychology specifically studies human thought and behavior, and often focuses on "abnormal" behavior or psychopathology (Keyes & Haidt, 2003). While the doctrine of sin cannot and should not be ignored, it should be given fair treatment within the arc of the biblical narrative—with its proper placement occurring between the doctrine of creation and the doctrine of redemption. However, this proper placement of the doctrine of sin has not always been practiced, and the negative aspects of humanity related to sin have often been treated in the integration literature without a balanced treatment of the doctrine of creation. Given the weight of theological reflection that situates theological anthropology within the doctrine of creation, further sustained reflection upon the doctrine of creation for integration purposes is warranted. Moreover, amongst contemporary Christian systematic proposals of theology, the *imago Dei* (or theological anthropology) is inextricably intertwined and situated within the doctrine of creation since theologians agree that the human creature is centrally located at the height of God's creative activities (Barth, 1936; Berkouwer, 1955; Moltmann, 1985; Pannenberg, 1991). For the Christian who studies psychology, the human is never only an object of study, but is a creature granted dignity and worth by the very fact that humanity is created by the

1. In a similar way, Duane Litfin's work, *Conceiving the Christian college*, advocates for the integration between faith and learning and encourages scholars to show the distinctiveness of a Christian framework for every subject (including psychology) within the academic disciplines (Litfin, 2004).

triune God, situated in the material world within the wide array of God's trinitarian providential actions, redeemed within the created world through the person and work of Jesus Christ, and sustained and sanctified through the life-giving Spirit (Barth, 1936; Gunton, 2002; Shults, 2003). This has particular bearing on both methodology and assumptions made in psychology (Whitney, 2013).

While it is considered normal for psychology to operate with some sort of functional methodological naturalism, for the Christian, methodological naturalism does not need imply a commitment to a comprehensive ontological naturalism (Hampson, 2014). Or said another way, while psychology operates in its research and methodology with identifying natural causal mechanisms for the various phenomena of human thought and behavior, this does not necessarily mean that psychology's answers give a complete picture of human existence. Psychology is ill-equipped to provide a comprehensive ontology, and for the integrationist, Christian theology provides the foundational ontology for the study of human personhood. Consequently, properly situating the human person within the wider context of God's triune creative actions is essential for the integration of psychology and theology since it reminds us, that for all of the benefits that psychological study may offer, the epistemic questions of personhood cannot be answered by resources within psychology alone (Hampson, 2014). Recognizing that Christian theology identifies a goal or purpose for humanity compels Christian psychologists to more fully grasp what God has intended for the human creature, and how this might have bearing on psychology. Moreover, a trinitarian understanding of creation informs how one might understand the human person in ways that are not necessarily in contradistinction to psychological study, but that remain outside the purview of psychological inquiry (King & Whitney, 2015).

This being said, the doctrine of creation is not the only doctrine to consider when approaching interdisciplinary work in psychology and theology. In fact, no theological doctrine exists in isolation of other related doctrinal loci. Creation is always set in the larger narrative of God's triune action through the Son and Spirit, and the working of the triune God for the redemption of the entire created realm (Whitney, 2013). According to Paul, all of creation groans in expectation of the day that it will be released from its bondage (Romans 8:18–24), and it is only with the account of what will happen in the end that we find out how the created order will be made new (Revelation 21).[2] Creation is a doctrine that has often been overlooked within the field of integration, not because it has been deemed unimportant by integrationists, but as mentioned earlier, it is often overshadowed by an emphasis on the *imago Dei* or sin.[3]

Before the twentieth century, the Christian doctrine of creation had never been an item of any major theological controversy, and was usually isolated and treated as a foreword to other areas of

2. 2 Peter 3:13 and Revelation 21 are two texts that explicitly speak of the redemption of the entire creation (both human and nonhuman). Especially seen in Revelation 21, there is reference to the new city of Jerusalem that still exists but is completely transformed by the glory of God. Here we find that earth is not cast aside to make room for the heavenly realm, but rather there is an *interpenetration* of the realms where God's creatures reside and the realm where God is, so that there is no need for sun—the glory of the Lord provides the light in the new city of Jerusalem. Here we are reminded of P. T. Forsyth's statement that God "does not come to grout the gaps in nature, not simply to bless nature, but to change it, to make a new earth from a new foundation in a new heaven" (Forsyth, 1916, p. 77).

3. A survey of the literature within the integration of psychology and Christian theology generally demonstrates theological material being integrated within the major subdisciplines of psychology (i.e. social psychology, cognitive psychology, neuropsychology, developmental psychology, cultural psychology, and clinical/counseling psychology). While the psychological research is well supported within integration, the field can be strengthened from a more robust treatment of certain key theological doctrines that directly intersect with theological anthropology—namely the Trinity, creation, revelation, providence, and eschatology. An exception to this in the integration dialogue would be Eric Johnson's *Foundations for soul care: A Christian psychology proposal*, which gives a thorough discussion of the key theological doctrines that intersect with the *imago Dei* (see further Johnson, 2007).

systematic theology (Schwarz, 2002; Fergusson, 1998). However, in the latter half of the twentieth century and beginning the twenty-first century, the doctrine of creation has risen to a greater degree of prominence in theological dialogue (Gunton, 2002, Fergusson, 1998). As a result, one finds that the doctrine of creation is being reexamined in theological circles, and part of this reevaluation has also raised awareness as to how the doctrine of creation relates and intersects with other various disciplines (Dyrness, 1997; Williams, 1999).

Al Wolters's work, *Creation regained: Biblical basis for a Reformational worldview*, is one contemporary example of how the doctrine of creation has received renewed interest in recent years. Wolters's work is a reappraisal of the Dutch neo-Calvinist tradition, and rightly asks the question of how the goodness of creation affects the biblical arc of the fall and redemption, since these items bear on how humanity engages the world around them (Wolters, 2005). Wolters's book incorporates many aspects of the Dutch theologian Abraham Kuyper.[4]

Keeping in mind Strawn, Jones, & Wright's notion of "traditioning" our integrative work (Strawn, Jones & Wright, 2014), it will be helpful for the reader to know that Kuyper and the Reformed tradition have also been influential for key elements of this article—particularly in relation to humanity's role in continuing to develop the created realm and shape it through culture. Although these tendencies towards the Reformed tradition are present within some elements of the article, there are no major instances where the perspectives outlined in this article would necessarily exclude other denominations or traditions from drawing upon the theological content relating to creation and integration.

A common misunderstanding about the doctrine of creation is to think the doctrine only describes the divine act of creating as outlined in the first chapters of Genesis. While the doctrine of creation *does* seek to give a description of how the world was made, it also functions as a unifying doctrine within the larger scriptural narrative (Fergusson, 1998; Gunton, 2002; King & Whitney, 2015). Creation in the beginning also assumes God's self-disclosure in and through time by Christ and the Spirit (the Trinity and Revelation), the triune God's continued provision to his creation (Providence and Common Grace), the goodness of the created realm as worthy of care, the human role in shaping the created realm through activities of aesthetics and science (theology of culture), and the forward movement of God's kingdom towards the new creation (eschatology). Consequently, the doctrine of creation describes the triune God's continuous and loving action of creating in the beginning, sustaining the world that has been created, redeeming fallen humanity, and ultimately bringing about the restoration and perfection of the entire created order (Barth, 1961). These movements of the triune God's action (creating, sustaining, redeeming, perfecting) provide the backdrop and arc of the narrative of what God has done and is still doing in the world. The triune God creates the material world and brings the human creature into existence. God graciously sustains the human creature and the material world through the Spirit. God redeems the human creature through the person and work of Christ, and finally, God perfects the human creature over time by bringing the Creator's original intentions to fulfillment along with the restoration of the cosmos (King & Whitney, 2015; Puffer, 2007).

Understanding the doctrine of creation within the scope of this larger narrative acknowledges that the triune God immerses himself in the messiness of human history, and, through the work of the Son and Spirit, graciously enables his creatures to thrive and have life. From this perspective, the redeeming work of the Son and the perfecting power of the Spirit enable creatures to become what they are intended to be (Hart, 2001; King & Whitney, 2015).

A trinitarian understanding of creation is an essential part to how one understands the human person since the distinct roles of the members of the Trinity establish the relational qualities that

4. Wolters's work provides a theologically strong account of how the doctrine of creation helps one think theologically about culture and forming a Christian worldview. Nevertheless, the conclusions of Wolters's introductory work are not intended to cover all of the ramifications that creation has for the various aspects of human experience, or for the sciences, or for psychology.

are foundational for human personhood and the connections that humans have with the rest of creation. If there is any relation between these theological ideas and what evolutionary biology and psychology have taught us, it is that the human creature stands in closer relationship with other creatures and the rest of the created world than we might have anticipated. A trinitarian conception of creation highlights the connectivity that humans have with the wider created realm. As Colin Gunton notes, God's existence as Father, Son, and Spirit establishes an ontology of relations for how one might understand the world and determines a "doctrine of creation which enables us to respect the diversity of relationships" found within the world (Gunton, 1997, p. xxvii).

Unfortunately, many evangelical churches and Christians today still operate with a thin understanding of the created realm that has been influenced by Enlightenment beliefs that separate humans from their natural world (individualism) and denigrate the goodness of the created realm due to dualistic conceptions of the world that (Brown & Strawn, 2012; Marsden, 2006; Yu, 1987). Enlightenment scientific understandings of creation typically leaned towards Deism—the belief that God was separate from the universe and only interacted with the world through natural laws that he had set in motion. Often, for theists who worked in the field of the natural sciences during the modern era, it was common to hold a deistic conception of the world that posited a "separateness" of God from the created realm (Schwarz, 2002).

Moreover, the ideological milieu from which psychology was born was firmly based in naturalistic and evolutionary accounts of human personhood, and in the case of experimental psychology, incorporated the scientific method in order to verify its findings (Tyson, Jones, & Elock, 2011). For example, Freud used his own theory of the psyche along with his understanding of nineteenth-century evolutionary biology to explain away the existence of God. For Freud, religion had served a purpose for past primal societies to curb instinctual impulses through a moral code, but now religion is not necessary. Freud argued that conceptions of God functioned as a defense mechanism and were really wishes for a father figure to keep one safe (Freud, 1961). Freud's theory, while providing the backbone for early clinical psychology and psychoanalysis, still operated with a very negative or low view of humanity. And it was Erik Erikson who famously evaluated Freud's view of humanity as essentially "tragic" (Erikson, 1963). Given the trajectory of creation, fall, and redemption and new creation from the biblical narrative (Puffer, 2007), it is important to note that the Christian perspective contrasts with various historical psychological perspectives that assume a low view of the human person. Additionally, it is important to note how the doctrine of creation provides the framework for upholding the goodness of the human creature despite the reality of sin—which provides a view of human nature that contrasts with some older psychological views of humanity that portray humans as either primarily "evil and destructive" (Freud, Klein) or "neutral" with one's behavior determined by environment (Skinner). That being said, more recent proposals in positive psychology and developmental psychology have begun to more intentionally ask what can go right with persons and behavior, rather than merely focus on pathology—and this view of the positive dimensions of human potentiality are more in line with the view of the human creature that is argued in this article (Benson & Scales, 2009; Damon, 2004; Lerner, Dowling, & Anderson, 2003; King & Clardy, 2014). With this intellectual history in mind, a thicker understanding of creation influences the framework of integration in two primary ways. First, a trinitarian doctrine of creation corrects any type of Christian theology (sometimes found in popular evangelical thought) that denigrates the goodness of the human creature or the exploration of God's creation through the sciences or psychological science. Second, a rich doctrine of creation from Christian theology offers a corrective to physicalism or naturalism, sometimes found within some streams of psychology, that reduce humanity to a series of behavioral or neurological processes.[5] It is to a more detailed description of these elements of creation that we now turn.

5. A current example in cognitive psychology that attempts to explain away the existence of God by reducing religion to an evolutionary byproduct is found in Jesse Bering's work, *The Belief Instinct*, (Bering, 2012).

Beginnings

A thick doctrine of creation establishes the goodness of the material created world and speaks to how God reveals Godself to the human creature. Genesis states that after the world had been created, God declared that it was "very good" (Genesis 1:31). The pronouncement and blessing that creation was "good" appears six other times throughout the creation story at the various stages of creation (Genesis 1:4, 10, 12, 17, 21, 24). Interestingly enough, there are a total of seven proclamations of goodness over the entire creation narrative in chapter 1. Within this first account of creation, we also have the creation of humans (Genesis 1:26–27) that holds a special place within the created order. As the narrative moves forward into Genesis 2 and 3, humanity is placed in the garden to shepherd or steward over the creation that God has given, with the text establishing that God has given tasks for humans to carry out in the created world. With the naming of the animals, humans are given a special role in organizing, relating, and classifying what God has made. The naming of the plants and animals can be seen as a relational task as humanity enters into a certain kind of relationship with creation (Brueggemann, 1982). This is a vital point to consider when practicing integration since any study of the human person can only be done by entering into relationship with another, even if we try to limit those terms of encounter to those prescribed by the scientific method.

The scriptural creation narrative demonstrates that God is purposeful in the manner in which he calls the world into being. The ordered nature of the creation story in Genesis is unique—especially when compared to other creation narratives in the ancient Near East like the Babylonian *Enuma Elish.* In this creation story, the world is created through the violent death of the Babylonian goddess Tiamat, who is ripped in two by Marduk and the halves of her corpse used to fashion the earth—while humans are created from the blood of a traitor god who also opposed Marduk (Davies & Rogerson, 2005, p. 45). As opposed to such violence, cruelty, and bloodshed found in the *Enuma Elish* creation narrative, Genesis stands out as unique from other ancient creation narratives by outlining that the triune God alone creates the world in an ordered manner, creates the universe out of love, fashions a world that is hospitable for human life, and remains in relationship with his creation. The world, as God has created it, is something that does not remain unknowable, but is able to be cared for and explored—and, as we will see later, this stewardship and exploration is one of the chief tasks given to humanity that directly relates to psychological study.

From this introduction of God's creative power found in Genesis, one finds that God's creation is good and has value, the created realm has an order, beauty, and splendor to it, and that creation exists because the Creator has chosen to extend his creative energies in this manner. The created world is the place where God has extended Godself out of love and made space for creatures that are fundamentally distinct from him. God has not only created a world that is hospitable to creatures that are distinct from him, but also clothed Godself in the material in the person of Jesus Christ. While the creation is not a god, it does stand in close relationship with its Creator. The human creature is also not a god, but is given special privileges, responsibilities, and relational abilities so that the human creature has potential to thrive and flourish (King, 2016).

The material realm is also a spiritual realm since it is the realm where God's Spirit moves in a dynamic way, and is the realm that Christ entered and took on flesh. This also means that there is both a very social and embodied notion to becoming who God intends for us to be given to us by the very fact that God has created a world distinct from God but still in relationship with God. And it was Irenaeus (d. 202 A.D.) who famously argued that since Christ became flesh, the physical, material created realm should not be discounted or downgraded as unimportant (Whitney, 2013). The human creature's relationships, emotions, and mind have potential in being shaped towards a certain *telos* (King, 2016). Incidentally, from the theological idea that God creates and makes space for other creatures is a primary theological basis for clinical psychology or therapy. Psychotherapy has potential to reflect that outline of creation presented here in that psychotherapy also creates space for another person and provides a hospitable space for another to thrive. Psychotherapy also is the genuine attempt to understand and enter into the world of another in an attempt to show love

and bring restoration in an incarnational way. While more will be said about this in the final sections on implications for practice, now it is time to draw upon some of these key points from creation that are valuable for the task of integration between psychology and Christian theology.

The Goodness and Order of the Created Realm

Having reviewed some key elements from the creation narrative, further theological reflection about this narrative reveals four key points that are not only valuable for academic faith integration but also essential for conceiving the relationship between theology and psychology. These key points are as follows, and each of these points will be expanded upon to demonstrate the particular relevance for psychology:

1. The goodness of the created realm establishes the investigation and exploration of human nature through science and psychology.
2. Human nature can be explored through psychology because God's providential care allows a certain "order" of creation to be preserved despite the reality of sin.
3. God endows humanity with creative abilities to discover and develop the created realm and culture through the science of psychology.
4. God's trinitarian relations with the created world establish the theological basis for the social, embodied, and relational aspects of human nature that are discernable through the study of psychology.

Conclusion #1: The goodness of the created realm establishes the investigation and exploration of human nature through science and psychology

Broadly speaking, it is a trinitarian understanding of creation that enables interdisciplinary dialogue to take place between theology and science, and between theology and psychology. This trinitarian understanding of creation provides one of the core elements discussed in the psychology integrative literature. However, it is most often discussed using the terms "truth" or "knowledge," or through the phrase "all truth is God's truth" (e.g. Carter & Narramore, 1979). From a theological perspective, truth (as integrationists use the word) is only possible because God, in his trinitarian relations with humanity, through the Son and Spirit, has created a world that is knowable and has graciously allowed knowledge or truth to be mediated through our embodied interaction with creation. Under this first conclusion, four key points stand out here.

First, the theological foundation for the frequently used phrase "all truth is God's truth" incorporates the interrelated doctrines of creation, revelation, and sin. While debate about the noetic effects of sin centers around how much truth can be discerned through unaided reason alone, the doctrine of creation establishes that truth or reality *is* knowable within the physical realm—and the doctrine of revelation speaks to how this truth is mediated to humanity and discernable through the sciences and psychology. In this case, the doctrine of creation paints a picture that God has made a world that is good and is knowable through human reason, and God enables a reality to exist that is discernable through psychology. Revelation describes the process of how God makes Godself known to his creatures, while the notion of *how* this actually occurs is an issue that theologians have been wrestling with for centuries. Christians will agree that God communicates to humanity; however, the manner in which this communication takes place varies between different denominations, and even within denominational lines.[6] Moreover, different models of integration

6. One well-known distinction is between Catholic and Protestant views of revelation. Luther wanted to isolate revelation as occurring through Scripture alone (*sola Scriptura*) rather than through Scripture and tradition, as the Catholic view advocated.

within the evangelical community typically operate with different views of general revelation and creation, and more will be said about this briefly.

Second, theologians have generally acknowledged two varieties of revelation: general revelation (also sometimes referred to as natural theology) and special revelation. *General revelation* acknowledges there is a self-disclosure of God that is given to all of humanity. This general revelation of God does not necessarily mean that this communication is able to provide salvation, but simply means that if God created the world, then something of God can be expected to be seen in creation (the classic texts that are used to support this are Psalm 19:1–4 and Romans 1:18–2:16). *Special revelation* acknowledges that God reveals Godself uniquely in the person and work of Jesus Christ, and also speaks to how the Spirit works through Scripture to illuminate hearts and minds to God's disclosure of Godself through Jesus Christ.

Theologian and scientist Alister McGrath (2001) insists that the doctrine of creation emphasizes that knowledge is unified. The natural order and Scripture represent two ways that one can know God, with Scripture embodying a more full and clear knowledge about God (McGrath, 2001, p. 212). As McGrath indicates, there are not two entirely separate ways of knowing God, one through general revelation and one through special revelation (as was Karl Barth's criticism of natural theology). If God made the world, then it comes as no surprise that aspects of God's order, creativity, and life would be found in the created realm (Green, 2008), and it is this unitary approach to knowledge that enables truths to be gleaned from psychology. Although this idea of the unity of knowledge from a theological perspective is not new, and is found widely in faith and learning literature (Litfin, 2004; Crouch, 2009), it is necessary groundwork to be reviewed. Moreover, those who teach integration classes in psychology and theology will find the unity of knowledge to be a foundational point for establishing some sort of guideline or methodology to enable students to practice integration.

Third, while general revelation through creation *may* reveal something about God, special revelation is clearer and more specific. While general revelation in creation may reveal something about God, what general revelation does more explicitly is disclose the *order* of the created world that God has made. It is this order that is observable through the science and study of psychology. T. F. Torrance, long-time professor of theology at the University of Edinburgh, similarly argues (with McGrath) that God has given the world a certain kind of reality that makes it knowable. Nature may be "interpreted as pointing intelligibly beyond itself to God," but creation does not "permit of any necessary inferences from its contingence to God" (Torrance, 1969, p. 62). God did not have to make the world this way, but chose to graciously create a world that humans could interact with, and in some way, come to understand through exploration. Like the parent who gets great pleasure from watching their children romp around a forest or new playground and examine some details of their environment, God gets great delight in watching his children explore what he has created on his vast playground.[7]

Consequently, while the created realm is knowable, the physical world can only speak about God in ambiguous or vague terms (Torrance, 1982). For Torrance (1971), theology is the unique science that is devoted to knowing God, while the natural sciences and social sciences are the "rigorous and disciplined extension" of that basic way of knowing through nature that is applied to "every area of human life and thought" (p. 91). Moreover, the psychologist who discovers aspects of these orders of creation or the human creature *may or may* not ultimately be drawn back to a belief in God. Even if a scientist or psychologist might be drawn to a belief in God from studying the order of creation, the full revelation of who God is in Jesus Christ is not possible without the working of special revelation. Or said another way, while general revelation through creation points back to God as the Creator, it does not necessarily point back to God as the redeemer of creation.

7. "God leads a very interesting life and is full of joy," Dallas Willard remarks: "Undoubtedly he is the most joyous being in the universe … We pay a lot of money to get a tank with a few tropical fish in it … but God has seas full of them which he constantly enjoys" (Willard, 1998, pp. 62–63).

Fourth, and a foundational element for those practicing integration, is the acknowledgement that creation and the human creature possess an order that is discernable through the psychological sciences. How *much* truth that one believes can be discerned through psychology determines the various positions within the integration dialogue. As mentioned earlier, the dictum that is often used in integration literature is "truth is one" or "all truth is God's truth." It is important to note that statements like "all truth is God's truth" assume an understanding of revelation that God's truths are revealed in creation, that these truths are knowable, and that truth can be discovered in the wider world. While these elements are widely regarded among those practicing integration, what is not widely acknowledged is how integrationists will differ as to how much of the world (or the human person) is discernable to humans through the study of psychology depending on their theological assumptions regarding the doctrine of creation, revelation, and how sin affects human apprehension of truth.[8] If the noetic effects of sin remain the focus in the integration discussion without acknowledging the doctrine of creation, then the dialogue tends to center on the corruption of psychology or the sciences. However, balancing the doctrine of creation with the noetic effects of sin enables one to speak to aspects of truth within the world and within the creature, while also acknowledging that these truths that are discovered do not necessarily shed light on humanity's estranged relationship from God and redemption offered in Jesus Christ (Barth, 1963). Calvin acknowledges that the noetic effects of sin and the fall *do* corrupt human reason, but even with this corruption, the order of creation still allows for knowledge of earthly things like government, managing a household, mechanical skills, and the liberal arts (Calvin, 1960). The corruption that Calvin primarily discusses remains humanity's inability to grasp spiritual wisdom of "heavenly things" (Calvin, 1960). Sin does blind humans to see the truth of Christ, but this blinding is not equal in all areas (Bloesch, 1997). Sin is pervasive in human life, but to infer that all goodness in humanity is lost, or that humanity has no capacity or ability to reason through disciplines like psychology, is to ultimately elevate the doctrine of sin above the doctrines of creation and redemption (Gunton, 2002). An elevation of the doctrine of sin over the doctrine of creation is commonplace among evangelical practitioners within the theology of integration, and the proper balancing of creation, along with sin and revelation, is an important step in order to understand how truth can be gleaned through psychology. Theological anthropology from a Christian perspective explores the intricacies of human personhood as it is rooted in the triune God, while psychology (from a Christian theological perspective) is the rigorous study of the order and nature of the human being while acknowledging the human person is a created reality that God has made (Gunton, 2002; Shults, 2003).

8. For example, the helpful and popular integrative work, *Psychology and Christianity: Five views* (edited by Eric Johnson), proposes five different viewpoints on how Christian faith integration should be done. Each viewpoint provides helpful features that demonstrate the variety of ways that faith integration can take place within psychology. Looking at the work through the lens of the doctrine of creation and revelation, the spectrum of the "five" views exists primarily because the authors hold differing theological assumptions regarding creation and general and special revelation, though this is not explicitly stated. More specifically, the various authors' views (generally speaking) line up along a spectrum to the degree that they believe the order of creation (truth) is discernable through human investigation of the world through psychological study. Thus, one determining factor differentiating one model of integration from another (at least in the *Five views*) remains a theological issue related to the doctrine of creation and revelation regarding how much "truth" the different authors believe can be discerned through human reason despite the reality of sin—which also has ramifications for one's understanding of knowledge and how this relates to embodiment. For instance, David Myers holds a view of creation and general revelation that is most open to certain "truths" being discerned through psychology while other positions are more cautious about how much truth is discerned through psychology because of theological differences regarding general revelation and creation. While the doctrine of creation and revelation inform *why* the authors hold different viewpoints on integration, these theological biases or leanings about revelation and creation are not frequently stated, and it would be helpful for authors and teachers of integration to state their theological positions on these subjects, since this has ramifications for their particular "view."

While all Christians should be interested in knowing biblical notions of human nature through God in Jesus Christ, they *may* or *may not* be interested in how creation (and the human creature) have an intrinsic logic and order that psychology can help clarify. On the other hand, all psychologists will be interested in the patterns of human thought and behavior while they *may* or *may not* acknowledge that the triune God established these intrinsic orders and patterns. It is left upto the integrationist to hold onto both of these notions when practicing the integration of psychology and theology. While all evangelicals engaging in faith integration in psychology will say that one's Christian faith needs to shape the practice and discipline of psychology, evangelicals will differ as to *how much* the discipline of psychology can actually clarify, broaden, or inform Christian theology depending in large part on their understanding of the goodness of creation, and the degree to which they perceive general and special revelation working together.

Conclusion #2: Human nature can be explored through psychology because God's providential care allows a certain order of creation to be preserved despite the reality of sin

God made a physical world and human creatures that have a certain order to them, which in the beginning God proclaimed as "good." These orders of creation can be observed through human interaction in the world through the sciences and psychology. However, the question remains: How *much* can we rely on the observations that one has about the world and human nature because sin is present? Hasn't sin destroyed one's ability to discern things accurately? And, hasn't sin completely corrupted one's ability to perceive truth? These are questions of importance, because, as mentioned above, one's view of *how much* sin has corrupted human ability to discern truth in the world also determines *how much* one believes that psychology can speak to realities about the human person through measurement, study, and evaluation. As mentioned above, one's theological position concerning creation and *how much* sin has corrupted human's ability to discern truth in the world, also determines *how much* (if any) psychological science can inform or broaden aspects of Christian theology. If one believes that psychology can yield insights about the human person (and most integrationists do believe this to some degree), then there has to be some theological conception of how this can occur even though sin is still present.

One way to make sense of how the order of creation is still intelligible to humans (both to the Christian and non-Christian) is explicated through the notion of "common grace" given to all of creation. Dutch theologian and statesman, Abraham Kuyper, notes that common grace is the view that God gives blessings to both the redeemed and the unredeemed. Common grace helps us make sense of how God works in the wider realms of culture outside of the church (which is vital to have some sense of when working within psychology). Common grace is God's movement through the Son and Spirit to develop human culture and promote human flourishing even though sin is still present (Kim-van Daalen, 2012). God's goodness of life is bestowed upon both the righteous and unrighteous alike—upholding the life of his creatures, and taking no pleasure in the death of even the wicked (Ezekiel 18:23). God creates, but does not leave creation on its own. He graciously reaches out to creation sustaining and perfecting the created order from destruction. Finally, it is the work of the Holy Spirit to restrain the power of sin so that its effects are not as bad as they could be (Kuyper, 2015), as it is also the work of the Spirit to actualize human creativity. As H. Richard Niebuhr (1951) reminds us, the world is "perverted good, not evil" so that the world is not "bad" in its being (p. 194). Kuyper also defined common grace as God's movement to restrain the power of sin and to develop "a sense of domesticity, natural love, the practice of human virtue, the improvement of the public conscience, integrity, mutual loyalty among people, and a feeling for piety leaven life" (Kuyper, 2015, p. 181).

There is much connection here with the Wesleyan notion of "prevenient grace." Both "common grace" and "prevenient grace" make sense of how goodness or aspects of truth are present in the world despite the reality of sin; however, the difference exists among the Reformed and Wesleyan tradition in how this grace leads to salvation (Cox, 1969, p. 143). For the Reformed tradition common grace is not

salvific, whereas in the Wesleyan tradition prevenient grace is the working in someone's life that occurs before conversion to lead someone to saving grace—while acknowledging that prevenient grace *does not always* have to lead to salvation since it can be resisted. Interestingly enough, both of these theological traditions have resources within their tradition for understanding how truth can be discerned although sin exists. Sin does disrupt the ordering of God's creation, within the human heart and in the structures and cultures of society—while not ultimately destroying God's good creation entirely. God is committed to both nonhuman and human creation, and this redemption occurs in the person and work of Jesus Christ and through the perfecting action of the Spirit (Gunton, 1995).

Common grace establishes how someone who might not be a believer might be able to find health and elements of wholeness within this life, even though he or she might not acknowledge God. Sin can and does pervert how humanity relates to God, but it does not pervert God's commitment to his beloved creation and the human community (Moltmann, 1985, p. 233). The Spirit continues to graciously sustain humanity—even those that move against God's commands. The order of creation is not completely destroyed by human sin or evil, and even though it may be disrupted, God's covenant love continues to graciously "overrule the worst that the human race can do to subvert his order" (Gunton, 1998, p. 192). Since sin does not destroy or corrupt creation entirely, and since God remains committed to his creation, then we must have room in our theology to speak of the "goodness" that is still present within creation. Additionally, as Calvin noted, for Christ-followers one cannot observe the wonder of creation and its goodness without it leading the believer back to the worship and glory of the Creator.

If one's theological leanings focus on the "badness" of the human being so that humans cannot discern any of the goodness that God preserves in creation through psychology, the doctrine of creation is subordinated to the doctrine of sin. While this focus on the sinful nature of humans is understandable, this focus has unfortunately often been interpreted that sin has (1) destroyed all of the good within human persons, or (2) destroyed completely humanity's ability to discern truth or reality within the physical world and through the science of psychology.

Conclusion #3: God endows humanity with creative abilities to discover and develop the created order through the science of psychology

God's creation of the human person and placing humanity within creation to tend and care for the earth naturally suggests caring or shaping of the created realm through human activity (culture). This is essential for those who teach the integration of psychology and theology since (theologically speaking) one can and should view psychology as an element of human culture, in that it concerns shaping and stewarding the world in a certain way. As has already been established, the order and unity of creation means that there is a world that can be investigated—and that truths can be gleaned through the human activity of investigation. Truth can be discovered in the world, and the human activity of psychology (and meaning making) shapes the created realm in a certain kind of way. Drawing on Kuyper, creation is not only *discovered* through the enterprise of science, but also *developed*. As Kuyper (1931) states, "And for our relation *to the world*: the recognition that in the whole world the curse is restrained by grace, that the life of the world is to be honored in its independence, and that we must, in every domain, discover the treasures and develop the potencies hidden by God in nature and in human life" (p. 31). For Kuyper, since humans stand in a certain relation with the world, they have the ability to *discover* the treasures of creation, and to *develop* these patterns found in creation. These two terms are helpful points for those practicing integration of psychology and Christianity, since one can assume that there are truths to be gleaned from the study of the human creature (discovery), and that as humans make meaning of these truths they *develop* a culture around these discoveries. Not only has God made humans naturally curious creatures, but also it makes sense that humanity's God-given relational capacities would make human creatures intensely curious about other

human creatures. Wolters reappraises this understanding from Kuyper and uses the terms of "structure" and "direction" (Wolters, 2005). Creation provides the structure so that the natural created world can be discovered, but it is up to the human working in culture to give these discoveries a *direction*. For Wolters, the Christian is charged with directing their discoveries to the working of the Kingdom, in whatever domain of study that they might find themselves in (Wolters, 2005). From the perspective of a trinitarian account of creation, the Spirit is the one who *particularizes* and *transforms*, and enables things to be what they are intended to be. This becomes evident in all realms of culture as humans engage in the creative and investigative process to give the creation a voice and shape it in a certain direction. The world's fundamental goodness is established through Christ who became incarnate, and humanity has the ability to transform and give direction to the world they are investigating as they are enabled through the Holy Spirit. From a theological standpoint it is the Spirit who guides human effort in this creative and directive process. There is something good about the created world, and there is something equally good when humans express their creative and directive capacities by engaging with the world that God has created.

With this in mind, one may understand that the study of the human person through psychology is a natural outworking of one way that the created realm can be shaped and studied. Through a theological lens, one can understand psychology as simply one way that humans express their curiosity and creativity through the study of human thought and behavior, in addition to making meaning of the things that one finds from the discovery and study of the human person (Gadamer, 1999). Humans are called to not only *discover* truths about the created order but also to *develop* these patterns that are found in creation—and these capacities of discovery and development are actualized by the work of the Spirit (Gunton, 1997). For Kuyper (1931), this human action of discovery and development has potential to shed "light on the glories of the entire cosmos in its visible phenomena and operations," and there is nothing either in the life of nature or in human life that does not "present itself as an object worthy of investigation" (p. 126). The importance of upholding the goodness and order of the material realm places greater emphasis on how one understands human action within the creation. And one also could argue that the discovery and development done within psychology concerning human thought and behavior have a special place within the sciences from a theological perspective since they specifically study the relational and personal dimensions of humanity, which, according to Scripture, is central in Christ's work of redemption.

Humans have a special role within the world of discovering and developing the created realm through the sciences, and this is a natural and good use of the gifts that God has given humanity. And to press this point further, earlier we discussed how the created realm is knowable but the physical world can only speak about God in ambiguous or vague terms (Torrance, 1982). Since the created world has an order that speaks, but speaks in vague terms, it is left up to humans as agents or stewards of creation to give articulation to the wonders of the human person through the science of psychology. According to Scripture, humanity is placed in the garden to shepherd or steward over the creation that God has given—with Genesis establishing that God has given tasks for humans to carry out in the created world. In the same line of work as naming of the animals, humans are given a special role in organizing and classifying what is discovered. This is another argument that establishes the value of the discipline of psychology. Humans find their proper place not in remaining above creation in some sort of hierarchy that dominates or destroys creation—but in recognizing their continuity (or relationality) with the created realm by rightly relating to God, others, and nonhuman creation.[9] This shaping of the world takes place—whether this occurs

9. Another improper view of creation among those interpretations of the Genesis text takes it to mean that humans dominate or stand over the created world in a place of ultimate authority (there is a difference between *dominion* and *domination*). Unfortunately, interpretations of the Genesis text that read "dominion" as "domination" result in the exploitation of creation for commerce and are seen in how some evangelicals despise creation or dismiss it for an otherworldly salvation, as American novelist Wendell has observed (Berry, 1973).

through plowing a farm, painting a work of art, performing research on human behavior, or exploring human nature and behavior through clinical work. While much of the work among evangelicals within integration notes that truth can be discovered through psychology, there is little discussion regarding how this discovery of the order of the human creature contributes to God's mandate of developing or fashioning the earth, and giving creation a voice (Begbie, 1997).

The conceptualization that has been sketched so far of the created realm helps give a theological vision for how God works in and through the human activity of psychology. If the created realm did not have a pattern or order, then the human enterprise of science or psychology could not take place. Moreover, if there is a crisis of belief that the created realm is good and something worthy in and of itself, this will dramatically impact various human cultural enterprises, and this includes the human enterprise of psychology (Gunton, 2002). This understanding of creation outlined also details how Christians may learn from non-Christians, so that truth may be discovered and human life informed and nourished from sources that are not specifically Christian, that is, by articulating the various forms and structures found in creation through psychology. Furthermore, if operating with a theology that does not affirm that human discovery in creation is part of a stewardship role to develop the created realm through psychological culture, then it will be more difficult to understand how psychology may contribute to our knowledge and understanding of the world. Psychology is exploration into the human person and behavior, and it can also be seen theologically as fulfilling our task as human creatures in exploring, developing, and shaping creation in a particular way. God has created humans with the ability to explore, wonder, dream, and develop creation—and psychology is one form in which this exploration or development takes place. The created realm presents a reality that has an intrinsic logic since it is from a good Creator—truth is accessible in the world through the secular, not because it proves the existence of God, but because God has ordered a world that is knowable to the one who investigates and explores. Psychology assumes that there are forms or patterns in the natural order that can be investigated, and psychological research not only helps discover truths about the created realm but also helps develop these truths.

Interaction with the material world is a necessary part of being human—what happens to and within the created world ultimately has significance for the ways that we become persons since our physical world shapes and orients the cognitive, social, and emotional dimensions of personhood (Brown & Strawn, 2012). Since the world is unified and ordered in a certain way, humans have been given the ability to investigate and explore the patterns found in creation, and ultimately give articulation to the order and patterns that are found regarding human thought and behavior. Humans shape the world in a certain way and at the same time human personhood is also shaped by the world that they inhabit through their discoveries and development. Additionally, it was noted that these discoveries hold potential to be developed and directed in a certain way, and for the Christian, these discoveries are offered up for the ultimate glory of God's Kingdom. While not all theories in psychology entirely align with the Christian gospel, one can still conceive psychology as a part of human exploration of the created order that God has established. This brings the discussion to our final conclusions, which is the situating of the human creature within the created realm, and is the topic to which we now turn.

Conclusion #4: God's Trinitarian relations with the created world establish the theological basis for the social, embodied, and relational aspects of human nature that are discerned through the study of psychology

Enlightenment scientific understandings of creation typically leaned towards Deism (God is removed from the workings of the world) so that that God was so separate from the universe that he only interacted with the world through natural laws. The natural sciences during the modern era touted deistic conceptions of the world that posited a "separateness" of God from the created realm so that God only interacted with creation through a series of natural laws. This picture that Deism portrays of God is the clockmaker who simply winds the clock and sits back as the world runs its

course with little or no intervention supernaturally. This mechanistic view of the universe resulted in several detrimental elements that were eventually incorporated into Western conceptions of the world and human person. They include: (1) the loss of the personal aspect of God's involvement with creation; (2) conceptions of the human person that were less holistic and more dualistic; (3) the loss of the connection between the human and nonhuman creation.

In the early twentieth century many evangelical Christians rejected deism, but as a result they stressed a more biblicist or literal interpretation of the creation narrative. This history of the influence of Enlightenment thought upon American evangelicalism has been well documented elsewhere, so those steps need not be retraced here, but the residue of this Enlightenment heritage still impinge on integration efforts in psychology and theology.[10] This history of the doctrine of creation and how God interacts with the natural world does have direct correlations with how evangelical Christians approach integration. A thin account of how God operates in the natural world will impact conceptions of integration resulting in divisions in how one understands the realms of the sacred and secular, with focus on spiritual development as something generally individualistic between God and the Christian—instead of Christian spirituality, salvation, and development being understood as operating in and with the physical world as the individual is embedded within a community (Brown & Strawn, 2012; Wright, 2008).

As mentioned, it is possible to discover truths about creation because God has fashioned a world that will disclose its secrets to those who inquire. The development and movement of humanity towards wholeness is something that takes place within this created realm, and consequently, change and transformation have an inherent *social* aspect to them. As British theologian John Webster observes, true humanity is not a possessed individualistic identity but "rather life in a perpetual movement of receiving and responding" to the gifts and the absolute generosity of the triune God (Webster, 2003, p. 228; King & Whitney, 2015).

The doctrine of creation offers a theological account of how God's free relations of love with the human and nonhuman creation form the structure for human development and human involvement with culture. However, human interactions with the material world are the primary point of study for psychology as the Christian psychologist understands that this remains the theological basis for relationality and embodiment. A rich account of the doctrine of creation affirms that humans are mutually *conditioned* and *constituted* by their social environment, and this stands in correspondence with what cognitive, developmental, and social psychology have demonstrated (Brosch & Van Bavel, 2012; Schwabe & Wolf, 2013). However, the Christian conception of this provides a rich *telos* that deepens our understanding of this plasticity and malleability; All creatures are formed in relationship to others (of their own kind or to other species), but human creatures are created with the capacity to be in a particular relationship with God and be open to God for transformation. Thus, true humanity is found in "participation in the unfolding of God's ways with humankind" (Webster, 2003, p. 228; King & Whitney, 2015). This is also informed by the basic belief that Christ's Spirit works to bring wholeness to the psychological and emotional aspects of personhood. Balanced with the doctrine of creation, this movement towards wholeness can occur within the created realm since growth and change happen by coming into a restorative relationship with another.

Three ramifications for psychology are found here. First, the relational and embodied aspects of humanity speak to the theological conception of embodiment that should undergird developmental and social psychology for the Christian. As mentioned earlier, Irenaeus's case is that Christ's incarnation legitimizes the value and importance of humanity within the material realm. Irenaeus also argues that the incarnation affirms life from infancy to adulthood, and makes the case that every aspect of one's life can be affirmed because Christ aligned himself with humanity. While Jesus did not live to an old age (at least to what we might consider old), Irenaeus still argued that all periods of human life were sanctified by Christ becoming incarnate. And yet, this point holds importance

10. See further Noll, 1986; Funkenstein, 1986.

since it is a reminder that all of the interconnected relationships and developing systems which humans find themselves embedded in are established through the doctrine of creation, sanctified by Christ becoming incarnate, and directed to a certain *telos* through the Spirit. God has given some degree of order to these interconnected dynamic systems that humans find themselves in, and it is these features of the created realm that psychology seeks to study and address. It is not only that the created realm provides the structure that is able to be studied, but it is also this particular realm that we inhabit which shapes our emotional, neurological, and social development. Given the malleability of our personhood and the dynamic work of the Spirit, it compels us continue to develop a theological conception of what thriving or flourishing looks like—knowing that a Christian ontology also provides notions of becoming and personhood that psychology cannot provide alone (Balswick, King, & Reimer, 2016; King & Whitney, 2015; Lerner, 2002).

Second, the movement of God of working towards restoration does not just mean wholeness between others and God, but, as Anthony Hoekema observes, becoming a new creation also means having a renewed relationship with one's own self (Hoekema, 1986). Surprisingly, theological exposition of this seems to be neglected in much of the integration literature—and represents an important topic for further research and reflection (especially for clinical work). The work of the Spirit not only gives us greater capacity for relating to others, but also has capacity to change our own self-image—and for the Christian, we believe it does, in order to conform us to make us more like the image of Christ. This is the dynamic working of the Spirit bringing about a certain *telos* of becoming that occurs through development over the course of one's life (Schnitker, King, & Houltberg, 2019; King, 2016). Thus, with the redemption of the created realm there is also the renewal of our how we view ourselves. Creation establishes that as human creatures we are relational beings that exist in relationship with God, others, and the nonhuman creation. However, to be human also means that we have some degree of relationship with our own selves. As Calvin has noted, there is a reciprocal relationship between knowledge of God and knowledge of one's own self.[11] Self-perception and understanding of one's self is made possible because of the inherent relational dimension of the created realm. Hoekema argues that one's self-image is often "either inordinately high (in the form of sinful pride) or excessively low (in the form of feelings of shame or worthlessness)" (Hoekema, 1986, p. 105). However, as Scripture reminds us, there is already a degree of respect and care for one's own self that is assumed in the command to love our neighbor as ourselves (Matthew 22:39). Love for neighbor assumes that there is also some degree of healthy self-love that is present—and self-love that honors who God has made us to be is different than selfishness. Therefore, transformation through the Spirit not only means that we treat others in a new way, but also for the Christian that we treat ourselves in a way that is commensurate with the reality that there is no condemnation in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:1).

Third, the social, embodied, and relational aspects of human nature outlined by a trinitarian understanding of creation bear on both the method and practice of integration between psychology and theology (Brown & Strawn, 2012; Sandage & Brown, 2015). As mentioned above, modernity's influence in the West resulted in conceptions of the human person that were less holistic and more dualistic, and had the tendency to separate mind from body. These tendencies are still present within evangelicalism, and also within some integration efforts that divorce information or knowledge from embodiment. Knowledge, in the biblical perspective, is not solely objective or information-based; it is relationally grounded and mediated. If knowledge is relationally meditated, then observation always moves one into relationship with the subject that is being observed and is never something that can be done in complete objectivity—as the scientific method often implies (Polyani, 1962). A danger in teaching integration between psychology and Christianity arises when

11. Calvin famously said that "Nearly all the wisdom we possess, that is to say, true and sound wisdom, consists of two parts: the knowledge of God and of ourselves. But, while joined by many bonds, which one precedes and which brings forth the other is not easy to discern" (Calvin, 1960, p. 35).

integration is portrayed to students as something that is simply theoretical apart from the embodied and ethical components of human personhood. Moreover, as Sandage and Brown (2018) correctly note, the work of integration does not just occur on the level of abstract ideas, but involves whole and embodied persons to do the work of integration. Stressing in our teaching that integration involves understanding one's social and cultural location for how one embodies the world, how this impacts theological reflection, and how this bears on one's study of psychology is not only important but essential for the integration of one's own self, and the development of the ethical dimensions of personhood (Sandage & Brown, 2015).

Implications for Psychological Research and Psychotherapy

The ramifications of what has been outlined above move beyond simply establishing the theological foundations for how the doctrine of creation impacts integration to also providing insight for clinical work, research, becoming a spiritually integrated person, and teaching psychology in the undergraduate and graduate setting. While all of these implications cannot be discussed here, the burden of this article has been to open the conversation and dialogue for how a trinitarian doctrine of creation impacts our understanding of integration. Having established the basic framework of how creation provides some valuable ways to approach integration, I propose, by way of conclusion, to further sketch how some of these notions might have implications for psychology in the realm of clinical work and some aspects of psychological research.

As Christ-followers who are psychologists, one of our roles is to join with the work of God in redeeming patterns of human behavior by helping folks understand how they relate to themselves, others, and the world around them either through psychotherapy or through research. Or to use "Kuyperian" language, the work of psychotherapy can help persons *discover* new things about themselves and *develop* these patterns in a direction that is helpful. In many cases, the relational patterns that we are unaware of often are the patterns that cause the greatest difficulties in one's relationships. With this in mind, we might understand the work of therapy as helping patients to understand and discover *how* patterns of the past causes one (often unknowingly) to act certain ways in their relationships and even towards one's own self. Taking what we established above regarding general revelation and common grace, we can acknowledge that these relational patterns can be discovered simply because God has made a universe and human creatures that have discernable orders and patterns. Once these relational patterns are discovered, the psychologist can work to develop these patterns of behavior towards wholeness—with particular focus on changing negative relational patterns. Negative patterns of relating are usually rooted in real pain or hurt from the past, and fortunately some of these patterns are also discernable through human relationship and inquiry. If we want to use theological language, our negative patterns of relating do come through our sinfulness but also as a result of us being sinned against. God's Spirit works through clinicians to bring wholeness and healing through the discovery of relational patterns. Moreover, we must also acknowledge that the Spirit of God is at work and leads those who are children of God (Romans 8:9–10; 8:14), and we can trust that this is happening as we commit clinical work to Christ. The development and movement of humanity towards wholeness is something that takes place within this created realm, between the clinician and client, which also demonstrates how change and transformation have an inherent *social* aspect (Sandage & Brown, 2018).

Common grace enables us to see that God can work positively in the field of psychology in ways that benefit humanity—especially seen in, but not limited to, those areas of psychology that work to promote the health and well-being of families, couples, and children. Thus, common grace is at work in the family therapist who earnestly helps parents reconcile in order to provide a safer home environment for their children. Common grace enables us to see how the clinician who works with those who struggle with a severe mental illness have been graciously given gifts to care for those who are

often overlooked in our society. These gifts of God's common grace do not bring salvation, but they are graciously bestowed upon people so that God's goodness may shine forth. They are glimpses and reminders of God's coming Kingdom—a Kingdom where persons are whole and complete human beings. The doctrine of creation and providence reminds us that God is committed to sustaining and upholding his creation, and common grace helps explicate how this might take place.

Agreeing with Charles Taylor, the individualistic and isolated Western notions of the self and personhood have resulted in depersonalization and disengagement within wider society—and unfortunately these have affected psychological theory and some streams of evangelicalism. Deism had the tendency to devalue the doctrine of creation so that both persons and societies became more disengaged from one another, and disengagement can be understood as standing apart from others and the world in a depersonalized fashion so that the "other" is treated as an object (Gunton, 2002). A neglect of the trinitarian doctrine of creation causes one to lose the interconnected nature that humans have with others, God, and even nonhuman creation. Thus, the outcome of modernity was an essentially rationalist conception of the human being and the world, that humans are essentially a mind. If we are only a mind, then we discern the world divorced from body and emotions. In short, the way that we are fashioned into the people we are supposed to be happens (or doesn't happen) through the ways that our personal relationships are ordered (this is also where our ecclesiology comes in) since the community of the church is the realm where such social transformation takes place to form a new community that loves and worships Jesus Christ. One way that findings in social and cognitive psychology help push or inform our understanding of creation is demonstrating and confirming just how malleable we are as humans in regards to our behavior, how connected and influenced we are by social realities, and how prone to bias we are due to our cognitive schemas that are shaped by social identities (Bartlett, 1932; Schacter, Norman, & Koutstaal, 1998; Bernstein, Sacco, Young, & Hugenberg, 2014). Given the prevalence of how social realities shape our view of others, our behavior represents one future direction that a theology of creation must continue to engage with since it reinforces the importance of the role that the church has in shaping and creating new social realities (Brown & Strawn, 2012). Historically, through much of modern Western society the personal and communal dimensions of human personhood have been overlooked *and* humanity's relation with the world neglected However, this trend is counteracted through resources found in a trinitarian conception of creation that stresses the relational, social, and embodied dimensions of personhood.

Psychology represents a certain way that humans explore the order and unity of creation by discovering, giving voice to, and classifying information regarding human behavior, biology, and nature. Humans inherently make meaning of this information as irreducibly hermeneutic creatures (Gadamer, 1999), and this meaning making is also part of humanity's God-given relational and creative capacities. Informed with a doctrine of creation that upholds the value of the material creation and sees the connection between creature and creation, one begins to see how, from a theological perspective, the field of psychological science shapes the culture as one explores and investigates the created human person. While the work through psychotherapy does not bring salvation, it nevertheless can be viewed as part of God's processes to bring wholeness to his creation. Consequently, Christians working within psychology are part of shaping the realm that God has given us with the view that God is bringing those we work with towards wholeness. God's love reaches far beyond the bounds of only the "elect"—it reaches out to the whole world desiring that all people, everywhere come to know greater wholeness and abundant life. Job 34:14 reminds us that if God withdrew his Spirit, then all of humanity would perish. God as creator sustains his good creation, speaking his continual "yes" to life as he upholds the human creature and creation from dissolution (Moltmann, 1985).

This also means that Christians who work in psychological research and/or practice psychotherapy have a part to play in extending this love and working for change, and this change often times manifests itself in the relational work that takes place as one interacts with others and

provides research that can give a "roadmap" for how to order one's personal relationships. As Christians, we understand that God desires life for his creation, and this involves the prospering and flourishing of human life. It is the personal relations that we have with ourselves, others, and God (and even nonhuman creation) that shape who we are. Moreover, the doctrine of creation informs how God's free relations of love with the human and nonhuman creation form the basis for human development and human involvement with culture (King & Whitney, 2015; Balswick, King, & Reimer, 2016). In this way, clinicians can be seen, in part, as helping to reorder the relationships and patterns of behavior through the social and relational aspects of something like psychotherapy or research. We have both sinned and been sinned against, which disrupts the normal patterns and order of relating with others. The material created realm is where humanity has suffered from sin, but creation also represents the stage where redemption begins and occurs. Clinical work, in part, seeks to help patients grow and change through a reparative relationship—and this is discernable because of the vision of creation that we have established, i.e. God has made these relational patterns and orders known and discernable. It has also been argued that psychology is unique and of value with its focus on the relational and behavioral since the realm that Christ came to redeem is the relational dimension of one's personhood. This emphasis on the relational nature of humanity set within the arc of the biblical narrative of creation, redemption, and restoration has also caused scholars to ask questions about what it means to flourish or thrive from theological and psychological perspectives, i.e. what is a meaningful and purposeful end to existing as a human? (McMinn, 2017; Balswick, King, & Reimer 2016; Volf & Crisp, 2015; Charry, 2010). The prospering and flourishing of human life is what Jesus' ministry of reconciliation is about, and working for God's Kingdom here on earth means working towards *shalom*, which is not merely an absence of conflict but is a fullness or wholeness to life. In effect, we can understand the reign of God to be a reordering and restoration of creation that has been disrupted by sin. *Shalom* is the wholeness that God intended for his creation and creatures, and, balanced with an understanding of the doctrine of creation, we can understand that humans have a role in tending, caring for, and being good stewards of the small part of the created realm that we embody as persons.

Concluding Remarks

This article has proposed a theological evaluation of the nature and work of psychology that is informed by the trinitarian doctrine of creation, and argued that the resurgence of the doctrine of creation in theological circles has also opened up new possibilities for how we conceive the relationship between theology and psychology. A thin account of the doctrine of creation limits the scope of creation to the first chapter of Genesis and neglects how it is effectively related to other doctrines (like revelation and common grace). When this is done the doctrine of sin is often elevated to a place of importance over the doctrine of creation so that the goodness of the created order and creature are neglected or even denigrated. Conversely, situating the doctrine of creation within the larger arc of the biblical narrative emphasizes the goodness of the created world and speaks to how God reveals Godself to the human creature. A trinitarian understanding of creation highlights the personal and communal nature of humanity *and* humans' relationship with the material realm that is of great value for integration efforts in psychology—and especially for establishing that the practice of integration includes integration within persons, and not merely the integration of concepts or ideas (Sandage & Brown, 2018).

A doctrine of creation that includes the notion of common grace gives clarity to how God's Spirit brings forth good things through psychology, whether or not a particular psychologist acknowledges God. Common grace is a valuable theological concept for integration since it establishes *how* one understands psychological discoveries made by non-Christians. Is all of psychology "fallen" and in need of a pristine "Christian" approach? Or, is God at work in the field of psychology in ways that benefit humanity—even though all psychologists might not explicitly acknowledge God? The

argument outlined in this article favors the latter view, and has demonstrated how one's understanding of creation and revelation dictates various positions within the integration dialogue.

While psychology is the exploration of human thought and behavior, it can also be seen theologically as one particular way humans can explore, develop, and shape creation in particular ways—recognizing that one's ability to explore creation through psychology relies on capacities given by God.

One can affirm that psychology is a science—and yet, for the Christian, it is also the activity of humans engaging in the process of discovering and exploring God's world. The more central concern for those practicing integration is the acknowledgement that through God's general revelation, the world and the human creature have an order that may be discerned by observations through the psychological sciences. This revelation may not directly reveal things about God as Redeemer, but this general revelation reveals something of the manner and order of the way that God has put together the created realm and the human creature. As mentioned above, this does not mean that all of this exploration and observation aligns with all Christian convictions, and yet, we can still acknowledge that the role of discovering and developing and making meaning of God's world is something that is part of simply being human.

The significance that this holds for psychology cannot be overstated. Just as common grace allows us to makes sense of the goodness found in creation, there are elements of truth that are worth discovering *within* and *about* the human creature. Kuyper, for example, argues that there are features within human life that are "worthy of investigation." Since the world and human creatures have patterns that are intrinsic to their existence, it follows that these patterns (especially of human behavior) are worth exploring.

It is possible to see the work of psychology, and more specifically the integration of Christian theology and psychology, as finding and developing these areas of "truth" that people possess and helping them understand their own patterns of behavior. It is possible to discover truths about creation because God has fashioned a world that will disclose its secrets to those who inquire. Moreover, the Christian experience is informed by the basic belief that Christ's Spirit works to bring wholeness to the psychological and emotional aspects of our person—and informed by a trinitarian understanding of creation—aspects of this wholeness can occur within the created realm. Moreover, growth and change happen best, both behaviorally and spiritually, in the context of healing relationships. Since God created a world that is knowable to the one who inquires, Christian psychologists can see part of their work as helping others to understand their own relational patterns and develop these to bring people into reconciliation with themselves and others.

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ORCID iD

William B. Whitney https://orcid.org/0000-0001-5638-3395

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Author Biography

William B. Whitney, PhD, LMFT, is Associate Professor of Psychology at Azusa Pacific University. He maintains a private practice in Pasadena, California, where he works with individuals, couples, and specializes in group therapy.

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